Politeknik Negeri Bandung	GENERAL ENGLISH 1	
	Lecturer: Dra. Siti Yuliah, M.Pd. Intan Sinta Dewi Rahayu, M.Pd. Setya Resmini, M.Pd. Mira Nissa Murti, M.Pd.	Skill Focus: Reading
	Duration: 4x50’	Topic 5: Topic and Topic Sentence
Equipment:	White board, board marker, handout, projector, screen, laptop	
Objectives:	After completing this lesson, you will be able to: - Understand paragraph, the definition of topic and topic sentence, the importance of the topic in a paragraph, characteristics of topic and topic sentence; - Use strategies to identify topic and topic sentence in a paragraph - Identify topic and topic sentence in a paragraph or a text in general and academic context.	
Student’s name		Date:

1. Identifying the Topic of a Paragraph

1.1. What is a topic?

When you read for the meaning, you should begin by looking for the topic. This helps you connect what you read to what you already know. In order to find the topic, ask yourself:

"What is this about? What is the general idea?"

Example a:

In the group of words below, one of the words is the topic for all the other words. Circle the topic.

Elephants Zebras African animals Lions Tigers

The topic is African animals. All of the other words are examples of this topic.

Example b:

In the group of words below, one of the words is the topic for all the other words. Circle the topic.

wheels tires brakes steering wheel seats doors car

The topic is car. All of the other words are parts of a car.

EXERCISE 1

In these exercises, you should work with another student. By discussing your work, you will learn more from the exercises and you may change the way you think about reading.

In each group of words, circle the word which is the best topic for all the other words.

1. air tank **water skis** clock face mask goggles

scoreboard fans basket wet suit surf board

2. referees scoreboard **basketball game** clock

fans baskets players coaches

3. air bags seat belts stereo speakers **car equipment**

anti-lock brakes spare tire windshield wipers

4. whales sharks dolphins **sea creatures** eels

octopus barracudas skates

5. string quartet double bass viola **violin** cello
6. tulips daffodils **flowers** hyacinths crocuses
7. pistachios cashews **nuts** almonds pecans filberts
8. Maui Kauai **Hawaiian Islands** Oahu Hawaii Lanai Molokai
9. Biochemistry Physiology **Medical Subiects** Neurology

Anatomy Kinesiology

10. The Old Man and the Sea **Reading for Pleasure** The Pearl

The Chocolate War The Incredible Journey Night

1.2 The Topic of a Paragraph

The topic is the word or phrase that best describes what all of the sentences in the paragraph are about. Words relating to the topic are usually repeated several times in a paragraph. Looking for these words can help you focus on the topic.

Example:

Read the paragraph and underline the words that are repeated. Then write a topic that is not too specific or too general.

In developing countries, poor people have suffered the most from shortages of clean water. There are several reasons for this. First, in many developing countries, the majority of houses in poor villages and urban slums are not yet served by a piped water system. People living in these places often have to walk many miles to find water and carry it home in jugs and plastic containers. Second, these people usually have few alternatives to the piped water supply. There may be water closer by in rivers or lakes, but this is often dangerously polluted. In poor areas, street vendors often sell water by the liter, but they often charge extremely high prices for water that is not always safe to drink.

Topic: shortage of clean water in poor areas

EXERCISE 1

Read each paragraph. Working with another student, decide which topic is the best. Make a check after that topic. Write "too specific" or "too general" after the other topics.

The Construction of Houses

1. People usually build their houses out of the materials that are easily available to them. In some areas, most people build their homes out of wood. This is true in parts of North America and in Scandinavia. These areas have large forests, so wood is easy to get and inexpensive. In many other areas of Europe, there are few forests left. Stone and brick are cheaper, so most people build their houses of these materials. In tropical regions, houses are sometimes made from plants that grow there. For example, in parts of Africa or Asia, houses may be made out of bamboo. Finally, in the very coldest areas near the Arctic, people make their homes out of blocks of ice.

   a. Materials used for houses **The best topic**

   b. The wooden houses of Scandinavia **Too spesific**

   c. Houses around the world **Too general**

2. Houses in hot countries have many features that are different from houses in cold countries. Houses in hot countries usually have thick walls and small windows to keep out the heat. In

colder climates and darker regions, however, people do not have to worry about too much sun and heat. The houses therefore have larger windows to let in the sunlight. Another difference is that houses in hot climates usually have an out-door living area--a terrace, courtyard, or porch. In colder climates, of course, people spend less time outdoors, so houses often do not have such areas.

a. The architecture of houses **Too general**

b. Houses in hot and cold countries **The best topic**

c. Houses with small windows **Too spesific**

3. One of the most famous houses in the United States is Monticello. It was the home of Thomas Jefferson, the third President of the United States. Located on a hill near Charlottesville, Virginia, it has a beautiful view of the surrounding countryside. The house is famous, first of all, because it belonged to a President. It is also a fine example of early 19th century American architecture. Jefferson designed it himself in a style he had admired in Italy. Many American buildings of that time, in fact, imitated European styles. But while most were just imitations, his Monticello is lovely in itself. Furthermore, the design combines a graceful style with a typical American concern for comfort and function.

a. The view from Monticello **Too general**

b. American architecture **Too spesific**

c. Reasons for Monticello's fame **The best topic**

EXERCISE 2

A. Read each paragraph and underline words that are repeated. Then write a topic that is not too specific or too general.

Mexico City: Water Shortages and a Sinking City

1. Like many other fast-growing cities around the world, Mexico City is facing severe water shortages. Many of its 20 million inhabitants receive only one hour of piped water per week. Others receive none at all for weeks on end. Those who can afford the expense build their own home water system to catch and keep rainwater to supplement the city water. The situation, according to international experts, is the result of a combination of factors. First, the system of pipes is old and poorly managed, with the result that the pipes lose almost 40 percent of the water that they distribute around the city. Second, the demand for water, which has grown with the rapid population growth, far exceeds the supply. Furthermore, the water is consumed not only by residents for household use, but

also by thirsty industries such as beer-brewers and soft-drink bottlers, and there is little incentive' for them to conserve[2] or recycle water.

[1]*incentive:* something that encourages you to do something [2] *conserve:* to use less

Topic: The causes of water shortages in Mexico City

2. The current water shortages in Mexico City contrast remarkably with the city's situation in the past. When the Spanish arrived at the Aztec capital in 1519, they found stone buildings and gardens set on an island in the middle of a vast series of interconnected lakes—an "enchanted vision," according to one Spanish soldier. The Spanish destroyed the buildings, and began draining' the water from the lakes to build what became Mexico City. For the next four centuries, the city was able to meet its water needs from springs, shallow wells, and the remaining lake water. In the mid-nineteenth century, the residents of the city began taking water from the underlying aquifer. [2] In the twentieth century, as water needs grew and supplies from the aquifer became inadequate, city authorities brought water up from two nearby river systems. Twenty-five years ago, they began piping in water from 80 miles (130 km) away. Because Mexico City is located on a highland, the water must all be pumped uphill at considerable expense.

[1]*drain:* to make the water flow away
[2] *aquifer:* a layer of stone or earth under the surface of the ground that contains water

Topic: Mexico City's water source throughout the centuries

3. Related to the shortages is another problem: the city is sinking. Other cities around the world (such as Venice, Italy) are also experiencing this phenomenon, but the situation is most dramatic in Mexico City. Some neighborhoods are going down by as much as 15 inches (40 cm) a year, or a total of about 30 feet (9.1 m) over the last century. The cause is simply the fact that water is being removed from the aquifers faster than it can be replaced by rainwater. As water is removed, the spongy soil dries up and becomes more compact,' and the city slowly settles down. The effects are evident. At the Monument to Independence, which was built at ground level in 1910, twenty-three more steps were recently added to reach the base from the current ground level. Buildings and streets have been damaged by the uneven settling of the city, and so have the water and sewage systems. Since the city is now 6 feet below the level of nearby Lake Texcoco, flooding has become a frequent problem and because of the poor state of the sewage system, the flood waters are often full of untreated waste.

[1]*compact:* packed or put together firmly

Topic: Water shortage's leads to sink Mexico City

B. Compare your answers with those of another student. If you disagree, explain your answers and look back at the paragraphs to check your work.

2. Topic Sentences

Paragraphs in English usually contain a topic sentence that lets the reader know what the paragraph is about. Although this sentence is usually near the beginning of the paragraph, it can also be found in the middle or at the end.

EXERCISE 1

Read each paragraph and underline the topic sentence. Remember, the topic sentence is not always the first sentence in the paragraph. Compare your choices with another student. If your answers differ, decide whose is best and correct your work if necessary.

Effects of Weather and Climate

1. Violent storms cause damage and deaths all over the world, but sometimes people make the consequences worse. For example, too many people living in dangerous areas can turn a storm into a disaster. In Bangladesh, the flat river valley often floods. In the past, there were few people in this area and they could escape to higher land. Now, millions of people live there and they cannot escape when there are floods. Sometimes, too, there is more damage than necessary because people do not build homes that are safe or strong enough. This was the case when a terrible storm hit southern Florida. Many people died or lost their homes because the wind blew away poorly-made buildings.

2. When summer brings very hot weather, many people suffer more than they need to. There are a number of ways to make life more comfortable in the heat. First of all, you can try to keep your home as cool as possible. It is best to close all the windows and curtains during the hottest part of the day. Then, when it is cooler in the evening, you can open them up again. It is important also to keep yourself cool by wearing loose, light clothes. Cotton is the best material for clothes in hot weather. And finally, you should try to stay calm and relaxed. You could even try a nap after lunch, like many people who live in hot climates. This way you are more rested and ready to enjoy the cool evening hours.

3. Scientists believe that the earth's climate may be warming up. This trend probably began thousands of years ago. Many areas of the earth used to be covered with ice that has now melted. However, in recent years, the warming trend has speeded up. Scientists think that part of the reason for this may be carbon dioxide pollution from industry and automobiles. The carbon dioxide mixes with other gases. This pollution covers the earth like a blanket and keeps it warmer. Another reason for the warming may be the fact that the earth is losing its forests. Forests are an important part of the earth's system for using up carbon dioxide and keeping the air temperature cool.

EXERCISE 2

A. *Each of the paragraphs is missing a topic sentence. The missing sentences are listed at the end of the exercise (with one extra sentence). Working with another student, read the paragraphs and write the letter of the sentence that fits each paragraph best.*

The Pollution of the Oceans

1. ____(C)___No one can calculate the quantity of solid waste that has been dumped' in the world's oceans, but the total certainly exceeds many millions of tons. For example, from 1880 to 1895, 75 percent of the solid waste from New York City was dumped untreated into the Atlantic Ocean. Although it is now prohibited by law, the dumping of solid waste, including wastewater sludge, 2 industrial waste, and high-level radioactive waste were common in the United States until 1970. Cruise ships and huge floating fishing factories still regularly dispose of their solid waste products directly into the ocean.

2. ___(A)___The earth naturally recycles water and refreshes the land in what is called the hydrological cycle. The hydrological cycle not only renews the supply of water, but cleans it as well. The process begins as heat from the sun causes sea water, 97 percent of the earth's total water reserve, to evaporate' and form clouds. Because water evaporates at lower temperatures than most pollutants, the water vapor that rises from the seas is relatively pure and free of the contaminants, which are left behind. Next, water returns to earth as rain, which drains into streams and rivers and rushes toward the sea.

3. ____(D)___ Chemicals, petroleum products, and other dangerous substances such as radioactive materials remain in the ocean, polluting it permanently. The polluted ocean water kills fish or makes them dangerous to eat, posing health problems for those who consume them. It kills the tiny sea creatures that are the source of food for larger fish, sharks, and whales. It also spoils a source of great beauty and pleasure when some solid waste is thrown onto beaches during storms. Discharged petroleum products are frequently found on beaches and they not only ruin the beach, the petroleum residue' kills hundreds of shore birds. Effect of dangerous substances

4. ____(F)___ Nonpoint pollutants are dumped into lakes, rivers, and streams that may be far away from any ocean. However, these pollutants flow, eventually, into the oceans. They can come from a variety of sources, from road salt to agricultural pesticides. One source of nonpoint pollution is runoff from farming, including fertilizers, manure, and pesticides. Another source is industrial runoff, including heavy metals, phosphorous, and many other chemicals. Urban runoff (oils, salts, various chemicals) and atmospheric fallout of airborne pollution are other sources of nonpoint pollutants that reach the oceans.

5. ____(E)____This includes water and waste from sinks, toilets, washing machines, and bathtubs. The problem with this type of waste is that it provides massive amounts of nutrients for water plants, such as algae, so that they grow rapidly. This sudden growth causes concentrations

or algae blooms, which use up the oxygen in the water. As the oxygen levels of the water decline, many organisms suffer and die, and the ocean ecosystem is radically altered. This can be prevented by the installation of waste treatment plants that prevent waste from entering the sea, but such facilities do not exist in many poorer countries.

1 *dump:* to get rid of something you do not want

2*sludge:* mud, waste, and oil mixed together *evaporate:* when a liquid changes into a gas
3*discharged:* to send out from someplace
4 *residue:* something left after most of the material is gone

Missing topic sentences:

a. Although the hydrological cycle produces clean water in the form of rain, it does not remove the pollutants that steadily build up in the oceans.

b. New laws and regulations make it difficult for people to dump their trash into the oceans.

c. The oceans have long served as a vast dumping ground for all kinds of waste.
d. These are just a few of the problems caused by using the oceans as dumping grounds.

e. Wastewater dumping is yet another major form of ocean pollution.

f. Some pollutants in the ocean are not dumped there directly.

B. Compare your answers with those of another pair of students. If you disagree, explain your answers and look back at the paragraphs to check your work.